Dear Department Chair,

During my accounting internship, I worked as an audit intern at Eide Bailly LLP, where I was responsible for assisting with audits, reviews, and compilations for a variety of clients. I reported to senior associates and managers, as well as having a lot of hands on work with the department head and partners. My day to day duties typically involved working through key financial areas such as cash accounts, accounts receivable, accounts payable, and equity. I worked in all sorts of areas of the audits though, just more often and heavy in these few that I specified. I applied these procedures consistently across all engagements, whether I was working on large clients with billions of dollars in revenue or smaller clients with only a few million. In addition to audit work, I frequently completed review and compilation engagements for smaller clients. During slower periods, I often focused on compilations because I was able to complete multiple in a single day while still maintaining accuracy and efficiency. Feedback was provided regularly through direct communication with seniors and managers, and I was able to improve quickly by applying that feedback to future engagements. We also had numerous check-ins with the department head, and everyday conversations as well. Feedback was very common and I got a lot out of this as I did not feel bad asking for feedback daily.

Overall, I believe that my internship objectives were successfully met. I gained valuable hands-on experience in a professional accounting environment and developed a stronger understanding of audit procedures and financial reporting. I went into this experience with only two accounting classes, and I feel like I learned so much more about everything related to accounting in this short three-month experience. I also improved my ability to work independently and manage my time across multiple engagements. I would often be working in a few clients at once, so time management and delegating tasks to myself was majorly important to learn how to do. While I made significant progress, I know that there is still room for growth, particularly in handling more complex areas of audits and developing deeper analytical skills. Moving forward, I plan to continue building this foundation through additional experience and continued learning both inside and outside the classroom. I also found it super interesting seeing my classwork that I was working on correlate with what I was doing in the workplace.

Throughout my internship, I was able to directly apply academic concepts from my coursework to real-world situations. My knowledge of financial accounting, as this was one of the only classes I had prior, was especially useful when working through account balances and understanding how different financial statements connect. One of the most valuable experiences was working on review engagements, which felt like a “mini audit.” I

enjoyed being able to work through an entire engagement from start to finish, completing every part of the binder and seeing how numbers flowed from one section to another. This helped reinforce my understanding of financial relationships and gave me a more complete picture of the accounting process. However, I also recognized that additional coursework in areas such as data analytics and advanced Excel could further strengthen my ability to analyze financial data and work more efficiently in a professional setting. Another thing I would like to add is, although it would have been helpful, I was still able to complete work and do a very well job on things, even with the little experience that I do have.

This internship played a major role in helping me better define my career path. It confirmed my interest in pursuing a career in accounting, particularly within audit or a related field. It also showed me some parts of accounting I am not a fan of. Over the next five to seven years, I plan to begin an entry-level role such as an associate, continue developing my technical and professional skills. I am also interested in a finance internship, so this may also sway my future career thoughts on the 5-7 year outlook after that. I am also strongly considering pursuing my CPA certification, as it will provide additional opportunities for advancement and allow me to take on more responsibility in the future. Long-term, I am interested in exploring leadership roles or potentially transitioning into a position such as a controller or CFO. I also have a huge passion for entrepreneurship and will probably do something with that on the side for a while.

Based on my internship experience, I identified several human relations skills that will be important to continue developing. One of my favorite aspects of the internship was traveling to client sites. I was fortunate to work onsite frequently, which allowed me to build strong connections with clients, experience different work environments, and collaborate closely with team members. Traveling also helped me develop better communication skills, as I needed to interact with a variety of individuals and clearly explain or gather information. It was very intimidating at first when I had client questions and I would run through them in my head numerous times before heading to the client's office, but eventually you just realize they are people too and it is just an easy conversation. Additionally, working closely with the same group of coworkers during travel allowed me to build strong relationships and improve my teamwork skills. Moving forward, I want to continue strengthening my communication skills while maintaining a strong commitment to professionalism and ethical behavior. It is very important to know where the line is in these situations.

Sincerely,
Alex Siebenaler